

Foundation Repair Cost Shock — Action Checklist

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DECODE YOUR INSPECTION REPORT

- ☐ **Read the foundation section of your inspection report in full before moving on to other sections, because this section contains the most critical structural information about your potential home.:** Read the foundation section of your inspection report in full before moving on to other sections, because this section contains the most critical structural information about your potential home.
- ☐ **Look for horizontal cracks, wide cracks, or cracks near corners in your inspection report, because these patterns indicate serious structural movement rather than cosmetic settling that requires immediate attention.:** Look for horizontal cracks, wide cracks, or cracks near corners in your inspection report, because these patterns indicate serious structural movement rather than cosmetic settling that requires immediate attention.
- ☐ **Note any language describing soil pressure, settlement, or foundation movement in your report, because these terms signal conditions that will likely worsen over time and cost significantly more to repair later.:** Note any language describing soil pressure, settlement, or foundation movement in your report, because these terms signal conditions that will likely worsen over time and cost significantly more to repair later.
- ☐ **Contact your inspector immediately if the foundation section contains vague language like 'normal settlement,' because vague terminology often masks significant structural problems that need professional evaluation.:** Contact your inspector immediately if the foundation section contains vague language like 'normal settlement,' because vague terminology often masks significant structural problems that need professional evaluation.

GET EXPERT EVALUATIONS

- ☐ **Hire a licensed structural engineer to evaluate foundation issues before the inspection period ends, because their specialized credentials allow them to diagnose root causes and long-term risks that general home inspectors cannot identify.:** Hire a licensed structural engineer to evaluate foundation issues before the inspection period ends, because their specialized credentials allow them to diagnose root causes and long-term risks that general home inspectors cannot identify.

- **Get repair estimates from at least three different contractors rather than relying on a single quote, because pricing varies widely and some contractors may recommend unnecessary or overly expensive solutions when they sense you're under pressure.:** Get repair estimates from at least three different contractors rather than relying on a single quote, because pricing varies widely and some contractors may recommend unnecessary or overly expensive solutions when they sense you're under pressure.
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- **Ask each contractor to explain which repair method they recommend and why it suits your specific foundation problem, because understanding the underlying cause helps you evaluate whether the proposed solution makes sense for your situation.:** Ask each contractor to explain which repair method they recommend and why it suits your specific foundation problem, because understanding the underlying cause helps you evaluate whether the proposed solution makes sense for your situation.
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- **Inquire about local soil conditions and how they affect your foundation's stability before signing, because regional soil composition directly influences the type and severity of foundation problems your home may develop over time.:** Inquire about local soil conditions and how they affect your foundation's stability before signing, because regional soil composition directly influences the type and severity of foundation problems your home may develop over time.

PROTECT YOURSELF BEFORE CLOSING

- **Use the structural engineer's written report as negotiating leverage with the seller before the inspection period ends, because you have maximum leverage during this window to request price reduction or repair credits.:** Use the structural engineer's written report as negotiating leverage with the seller before the inspection period ends, because you have maximum leverage during this window to request price reduction or repair credits.
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- **Research your state's disclosure laws regarding foundation defects before finalizing your purchase, because disclosure requirements vary significantly by state and affect your legal recourse if problems emerge after closing.:** Research your state's disclosure laws regarding foundation defects before finalizing your purchase, because disclosure requirements vary significantly by state and affect your legal recourse if problems emerge after closing.
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- **Include foundation repair costs as a separate budget line item when calculating total home purchase expenses, because repairs can range from \$500 to \$200,000 or more and could dramatically change your financial picture.:** Include foundation repair costs as a separate budget line item when calculating total home purchase expenses, because repairs can range from \$500 to \$200,000 or more and could dramatically change your financial picture.
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- ☐ **Walk away from the purchase if the seller refuses to address documented foundation issues after professional evaluation, because post-closing responsibility leaves you with no negotiating leverage and full financial liability for repairs.:** Walk away from the purchase if the seller refuses to address documented foundation issues after professional evaluation, because post-closing responsibility leaves you with no negotiating leverage and full financial liability for repairs.

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